StoryCast Research Document
Information architecture, design decisions and accessibility rationale
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1. Project summary

StoryCast is a three-page microsite for audio and video storytelling. It is built with semantic HTML5, Sass compiled to CSS, CSS Grid, Flexbox and a container-queried media card, without frameworks. The goal is simple: a story should be usable by everyone, whether they listen, read, navigate by keyboard or use a screen reader.

2. Audience and needs

The design started from the people most often left out by media sites.

User group	What they need	How StoryCast responds
Deaf and hard-of-hearing visitors	A text equivalent of every sound	Full inline transcript, downloadable .txt transcript, WebVTT captions on video
Blind and low-vision visitors	Logical structure, labelled media, alt text	Landmarks, one h1 per page, ordered headings, descriptive alt text, labelled players
Keyboard and switch users	Reach everything without a mouse	Skip link, native controls, visible orange focus ring, scrollable transcript is focusable
Mobile and small-screen users	Readable layouts and large tap targets	Fluid grids, single-column stacking, relative units
Users in noisy places or on slow data	Read instead of listen	Transcript below the player; images lazy-loaded below the fold, small compressed media

3. Information architecture

The site is deliberately small: three pages, each with one clear purpose, and every page reachable from every other in one click through the primary navigation.

Home : index.html

About & Access : about.html

Story Detail : story/where-learning-begins.html

Page	Purpose	Key content
Home (index.html)	Introduce StoryCast and route visitors to stories	Hero, featured story, list of recent story cards
Story Detail (story/where-learning-begins.html)	Let a visitor experience one story fully	Breadcrumb, audio player, photos, captioned video, transcript, related stories, accessibility summary
About & Access (about.html)	Explain the mission and how access features work	Mission, six accessibility features, about the creator, how to engage

Why this shape. A flat three-page structure keeps navigation predictable, which is itself an accessibility benefit: there are no menus or hidden levels. The Story page puts the media first and the transcript directly beneath it, so the text alternative is never more than a scroll away. Related stories sit in a sidebar so a visitor who finishes a story has a next step.

Navigation. The primary navigation is identical on every page, with aria-current="page" marking the active page. A breadcrumb on the Story page shows the path back to Home, and the footer repeats the main links.

4. Design decisions

Colour

A deep navy background with white text and a bright blue accent gives a calm, focused listening environment. Orange is used only for the focus ring and skip link so it is distinctive and never confused with ordinary links.

Role	Hex	Used for
Background	#0a1628	Page background
Surface	#0f2044	Header, footer, cards, players
Border	#1e3a6e	Dividers and card outlines
Accent	#4da6ff	Links, tags, logo highlight
Button	#0b6fd6	Primary button background (white text)
Muted text	#a0b4cc	Secondary text
Focus	#f97316	Focus ring and skip link

Typography

Inter, with a system-ui fallback. It is highly legible at small sizes. Body text is 16 px with a 1.6 line height, headings use a tighter 1.2, and paragraph width is capped (65 to 72 characters) for comfortable reading. The h1 scales fluidly with clamp().

Layout

CSS Grid handles page-level layout (story grid, story page with sidebar, about grid). Flexbox handles components (header, navigation, card bodies, meta rows). A media-card component uses a container query

so it adapts to the space it is given rather than to the viewport.

5. Accessibility rationale (WCAG 2.1 AA)

Contrast ratios were calculated with the WCAG relative-luminance formula for the colour pairs used on the site:

Pair	Ratio	Requirement	Result
White on background (#ffffff / #0a1628)	18.1:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on background (#a0b4cc / #0a1628)	8.5:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on surface (#a0b4cc / #0f2044)	7.6:1	4.5:1	Pass
Muted text on transcript panel (#a0b4cc / #162d5e)	6.3:1	4.5:1	Pass
Accent links on background (#4da6ff / #0a1628)	7.1:1	4.5:1	Pass
White on primary button (#ffffff / #0b6fd6)	4.9:1	4.5:1	Pass
Focus ring on background (#f97316 / #0a1628)	6.5:1	3:1 (non-text)	Pass

- **Text alternatives:** every audio and video item has a transcript or captions; every informative image has descriptive alt text.
- **Structure:** header, nav, main, article, section, aside, figure/figcaption and footer landmarks; one h1 per page.
- **Keyboard:** skip-to-content link, native media controls, :focus-visible outlines, and a focusable scrollable transcript region.
- **ARIA only where needed:** aria-labelledby on sections, aria-label to distinguish the two navigation landmarks, aria-current on the active link.
- **Motion:** the site uses no auto-playing media and no animation beyond short colour transitions.

6. Responsive strategy

The layout is built mobile-first in principle and verified at three ranges: below 480 px (header stacks, buttons stack, single-column cards), 480 to 767 px (tighter spacing and smaller headings) and 768 px and up (two-column featured story and about grid). At 1024 px the Story page becomes a two-column layout with a sidebar. The media card is wrapped in a container-type: inline-size element and switches from a stacked layout to a horizontal image-plus-text layout when its container is wide enough.

7. Process, trade-offs and limitations

- The site has one detail page by design, because the brief asks for a single story page. The Home page cards link to its two sections (Isunzu Yacu and Bigogwe), and one card is marked coming soon.
- The story audio is the author's own recording, and the transcript is written to match it. Photos and videos were taken by the author during the visits.

- Accessibility was checked by manual keyboard testing, contrast calculation and heading-order review. A fuller audit with a screen reader and an automated checker (such as WAVE or Lighthouse) is recommended before launch.

8. Design files

Figma:

https://www.figma.com/design/jxJdBJ9OUts7twpTzecKPd/StoryCast-%E2%80%94-IA---Mockups?node-id=0-1&t=8MjdGsho2GTTeErf-1

Repository: https://github.com/divine150-coder/storycast